Lesson 1: Templates That Write Themselves

Module 1 | 60 minutes | Templates and merge | Adults (18+) · ages 18–65

Objective: Turn the messages you send every week into reusable prompt templates with placeholders, build personal messages with a sheet formula or mail merge without the AI seeing your real list, and start a template library.

Success criteria

- I can turn a repeated message into a prompt template with placeholders.
- I can get a mail-merge style formula from AI and build personal messages in a sheet.
- I can preview merged messages and catch a renamed or empty field.
- I can start a template library with notes on when to use each template.

Key vocabulary

- **template**: A message or prompt you write once and reuse, changing only the blanks.
- **placeholder**: A blank like [Customer name] that marks what changes each time.
- **merge field**: A blank like {{First Name}} that mail merge fills from a column in your sheet.
- **mail merge**: Joining one template with a list so each person gets their own personal message.
- **template library**: One place where you keep your templates with notes on when to use them.

You will need

- Projector or screen share with Kitabash and the AI tools for this lesson
- Devices: 1 per learner (laptop, tablet or phone)
- Learner accounts only where allowed: see the course safety notes
- Printed worksheet (optional)
- Project files: fee_reminders_practice.csv, l01_template_library_kit.md, l01_teacher_demo_script.md

Timed lesson plan (60 min)

Time	Stage	What happens
5 min	**Warm-up game**	“Spot the blanks” team race (see Unplugged). Link the circled words to placeholders.
4 min	**Watch + poll**	Play the lesson video. Poll in the chat: “How many times did you send nearly the same message last week?” (type a number).
6 min	**Live demo**	Fee reminder template, the renamed-field catch, the F2 formula filled down, and where Gmail/Outlook templates live.
10 min	**Build along (pairs)**	Build steps 1–5 with the practice CSV. Halfway thumbs check: “Thumbs up when column F shows 8 correct messages.”

9 min	**Prompt Labs**	Prompt Lab: a reusable prompt template, then Prompt Lab: a mail-merge formula. Paste each into a chatbot and test.
7 min	**Team games**	Quick competition: “Make a template or write it fresh?” sort in two teams, then the template-parts match as a speed round.
7 min	**Breakout pairs**	Pairs swap one template and try to “break” it: rename a field or remove the no-new-facts line, then see what the AI does. Then the mail-merge question.
5 min	**Show-and-tell**	Three learners show one template from their library and the time it will save each week.
4 min	**Probe**	New situation: the missing amount (individual).
3 min	**Wrap-up**	Exit ticket and homework: five weekly templates in the library.

Unplugged warm-up

Spot the blanks (5 min): put three real-looking messages on screen (a fee reminder, a pickup reminder, a meeting invite). Teams race to circle every word that would change next time (names, dates, amounts, places). The team with the most correct circles wins. Then say: “Those circles are your placeholders. Today we turn these into templates.”

Teaching the idea

Level 1 ended with one AI routine. Level 2 makes routines run with less typing. Today is templates: a prompt template is a saved prompt with [placeholders]; a message template is finished text with merge fields. The big idea for privacy is that the AI writes the template and the sheet fills in the real names, so the real list never goes into a chatbot. Show both ways to fill a template: a sheet formula that builds each message (works for everyone) and mail merge (Word with Outlook, or Gmail on some Workspace accounts). The caught mistake is a renamed field: the AI changes {{Due Date}} to {{Date}} and the merge leaves a blank.

Analogy: A template is like a rubber stamp with a blank space: you carve it carefully once, then stamp it a hundred times and write only the name in the space.

Live demo: 1) Open ChatGPT (or any chatbot) and type the fee reminder prompt from the video, with the four merge fields. 2) Read the reply aloud and ask: “Do all four field names match exactly?” If the AI renamed one, celebrate the catch; if not, show the {{Date}} example from the video. 3) Open fee_reminders_practice.csv in Google Sheets. 4) In Gemini or ChatGPT, ask for the F2 formula with the example sentence; paste it into F2 and drag down. 5) Read rows 2, 5 and 8 aloud and check name, amount and date. 6) Show where Gmail templates are turned on (Settings, advanced) or Outlook’s My Templates, and mention Word’s Mailings tab for mail merge. 7) Point out that the chatbot never saw the list.

Questions to ask

Ask	Listen for

What is the difference between a placeholder and a merge field?	A placeholder is a blank you fill in a prompt; a merge field is a blank mail merge fills from a sheet column.
Why does the AI not need your real customer list?	It only writes the template; the sheet or mail merge fills in the real details.
A preview shows an empty gap. What do you check first?	Whether the field name in the template exactly matches the column heading.
Name two lines that make a template safer.	Do not add any facts; keep the placeholders/merge fields exactly as written (also a length limit).
Which messages should NOT be templates?	Sensitive, personal or legal ones, like condolences or a reply to a legal notice.

Differentiation

Support
Give learners the ready-made fee reminder template and the finished F2 formula from the kit; they only change the wording and check three rows.

Stretch
Add a Language column: ask the AI for an IF formula that builds the Hindi message when column E says Hindi and the English one otherwise, then have a Hindi speaker check the meaning.

Common misconceptions

Misconception	How to fix it
To personalise messages, I must paste my customer list into the AI.	The AI writes the template; the sheet fills in names. The list stays with you.
The AI will keep my field names as I typed them.	It sometimes renames them. Check every field name against the sheet headings.
A template means every message sounds robotic.	Write it in your own warm voice once; personal details make each message feel personal.
If I do not have mail merge, I cannot do this.	A sheet formula builds every message; copy them or use your company's approved tool.

Assessment

Use the Prompt Lab results (auto-checked), the quick checks and the Probe answers. Written answers arrive in your review queue.

Exit ticket

Your merge preview says “Dear , your order is ready.” What is the most likely cause, and what is your fix?

Homework

Finish your five weekly templates in the library kit. Use one of them for real this week (with your own list kept in your sheet) and note the minutes saved.

Answer key — Kitabash activities

1. Prompt Lab: a reusable prompt template (perform · ai lab)

Checklist: Use placeholders for the details that change · Say who it is for · Set the tone · Set the length or format · Tell the AI not to invent facts · Keep the placeholders unchanged

Strong example:

```
You are the polite assistant of a courier booking counter. Write a short WhatsApp
message to a business customer, [Customer name], confirming their pickups this week:
[Number of parcels] parcels on [Pickup date] between [Pickup time]. Ask them to keep the
parcels packed and labelled. Under 50 words, friendly and professional. Do not add any
facts, charges or promises. Keep the placeholders exactly as written in square brackets.
```

2. Prompt Lab: a mail-merge formula (perform · ai lab)

Checklist: Name your app · Describe the columns · Give an example of the finished message · Ask for neat formatting of amount and date · Ask how to fill every row · Ask for a simple explanation

Strong example:

```
In Google Sheets, column A is First Name, column B is Batch, column C is Amount Due and
column D is Due Date. Write one formula for F2 that builds a reminder like this example:
“Hello! Gentle reminder: the fee of ₹2,500 for Aarav’s Class 9 Maths batch is due on 10
Nov.” Format the amount with commas and the date like 10 Nov. Tell me how to fill it
down to every row, and explain the formula in simple words.
```

3. Match each part of a good template to the job it does (perform · matching)

[Placeholders] like [Due date] → Mark exactly what changes each time · “Do not add any facts” → Stops the AI inventing fees, dates or promises · “Keep the merge fields exactly as written” → Stops a renamed field from leaving a blank · “Under 50 words” → Keeps a WhatsApp message easy to read · A “when to use” note in the library → Helps a colleague pick the right template fast

4. Make a template, or write it fresh each time? (perform · categorize)

Make a template (it repeats): Weekly pickup reminder to business customers, Monthly fee reminder to parents, Diwali greeting to all customers, Monday review meeting invite, Welcome email for every new joiner
Write it fresh (one-off or sensitive): Condolence message to a colleague who lost a parent, Apology to one client for a serious billing mistake, Reply to a legal notice

5. What does the AI need to see? (perform · multiple choice)

Answer: Only the message template with placeholders; the sheet fills in the real names on her own computer or company account

6. New situation: the missing amount (probe · multiple choice)

Answer: A field name in the template does not match the sheet heading (for example {{Amount}} vs “Amount Due”); fix the name and preview again

Answer key — worksheet

1. **Key words:** template = A message or prompt you write once and reuse, changing only the blanks. · placeholder = A blank like [Customer name] that marks what changes each time. · merge field = A blank like {{First Name}} that mail merge fills from a column in your sheet. · mail merge = Joining one template with a list so each person gets their own personal message.
2. **Prompt Lab: a reusable prompt template:** Include: Use placeholders for the details that change; Say who it is for; Set the tone; Set the length or format; Tell the AI not to invent facts; Keep the placeholders unchanged. Example: You are the polite assistant of a courier booking counter. Write a short WhatsApp message to a business customer, [Customer name], confirming their pickups this week: [Number of parcels] parcels on [Pickup date] between [Pickup time]. Ask them to keep the parcels packed and labelled. Under 50 words, friendly and professional. Do not add any facts, charges or promises. Keep the placeholders exactly as written in square brackets.
3. **Prompt Lab: a mail-merge formula:** Include: Name your app; Describe the columns; Give an example of the finished message; Ask for neat formatting of amount and date; Ask how to fill every row; Ask for a simple explanation. Example: In Google Sheets, column A is First Name, column B is Batch, column C is Amount Due and column D is Due Date. Write one formula for F2 that builds a reminder like this example: “Hello! Gentle reminder: the fee of ₹2,500 for Aarav’s Class 9 Maths batch is due on 10 Nov.” Format the amount with commas and the date like 10 Nov. Tell me how to fill it down to every row, and explain the formula in simple words.
4. **Match each part of a good template to the job it does:** [Placeholders] like [Due date] → Mark exactly what changes each time · “Do not add any facts” → Stops the AI inventing fees, dates or promises · “Keep the merge fields exactly as written” → Stops a renamed field from leaving a blank · “Under 50 words” → Keeps a WhatsApp message easy to read · A “when to use” note in the library → Helps a colleague pick the right template fast
5. **Make a template, or write it fresh each time?:** Make a template (it repeats): Weekly pickup reminder to business customers, Monthly fee reminder to parents, Diwali greeting to all customers, Monday review meeting invite, Welcome email for every new joiner · Write it fresh (one-off or sensitive): Condolence message to a colleague who lost a parent, Apology to one client for a serious billing mistake, Reply to a legal notice

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